

PROJECT PROPOSAL: SOCIAL ISOLATION AMONG UST STUDENTS

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BACKGROUND

- Social isolation refers to limited or lack of meaningful social connections
- Loneliness is the feeling of being alone or disconnected from others
- Both are strongly linked to depression, anxiety, and perceived stress among college students
- Students face higher risk during transitions such as moving away from home and academic pressure
- On-campus students may struggle with forming deep connections, while commuting students have fewer opportunities to engage
- National data show many college students report loneliness, stress, and emotional exhaustion
- Social isolation is also linked to poor sleep, lower academic performance, and unhealthy coping behaviors such as substance use

Source: ACHA (2024); Flesaker et al., 2025

PROPOSED PRIMARY DATA COLLECTION TOOL

- Data will be collected through an online survey, using a mix of Likert scale questions and short answer questions
- Featuring a validated tool—UCLA Loneliness Scale (Russell, 1996)
- Recruitment will be digital and in-person; flyers in public spaces, Residence life/RA announcements, and convenience sampling
- A survey was chosen as the primary data collection tool because it is the most effective way to reach a broad sample of undergraduate students, including those who may be experiencing higher levels of social isolation and are less likely to engage in in-person research settings
- Surveys provide a low-pressure, self-paced format that allows students to respond privately without the stress or social discomfort of face-to-face interviews, which is especially important when studying sensitive topics like loneliness and social isolation



PROPOSED SOLUTION

- College students, especially during transition periods, often need increased guidance and structured support to help build community and foster meaningful social connections during their adjustment to new academic and social environments – colleges must provide this
- Our proposed solution to addressing social isolation among University of St. Thomas undergraduate students is through the creation and integration of a new first year program called the UST FYEX Connection Program
- This program aims to help first-year students specifically in their transition to college, as this is a time with the most uncertainty for many students
- The program will be embedded within the First Year Experience (FYEX) course required by all UST first-years
- It will be a peer-centered program where students can connect and create a relationship to their peer mentor, orienting them to campus resources while also fostering social connections early on within college



EVIDENCE BASED JUSTIFICATION

Figure 1: Comparison of Social Isolation Among Local (Minnesota Undergrads) vs. National

Undergraduate Students

Measure	UMN Twin Cities (%)	National Benchmark (%)	Difference (%)
Frequent Social Isolation	34.2	28	+6.2
Moderate-to-Severe Anxiety	31.5	34	-2.5
Moderate-to-Severe Depression	36.7	32	+4.7

- Research shows loneliness is common among college students and affects mental health
- Higher loneliness is linked to increased depression, anxiety, and perceived stress
- Students with low social support report worse mental health outcomes
- Loneliness is associated with unhealthy coping behaviors, including substance use
- National College Health Assessment data show many students feel overwhelmed and emotionally exhausted
- Strong social connections improve well-being and academic adjustment
- Minnesota Social Isolation marks higher than the national benchmark (gap at a private, smaller institution like UST).

CREATIVE PRODUCT: FYEX CONNECTION PROGRAM

General Program Brief:

- The FYEX Connection Program embeds First-Year Connectors (trained upperclassmen) into FYEX seminars to reduce social isolation and increase student belonging
- “Connectors” facilitate weekly peer-led activities, movement (kinesthetic learning)-based engagement, small-group bonding, and 1:1 check-ins with students.
- The program is integrated into a required first-year course (FYEX), ensuring consistent access for all students rather than optional participation
- Includes a digital support layer (Canvas + messaging platforms) to reinforce reflection and ongoing connection

CREATIVE PRODUCT: FYEX CONNECTION PROGRAM

FRAMEWORK

Program Type: Peer-led, course-embedded first-year support program

Setting: Required First-Year Experience (FYEX) seminars

Key Components:

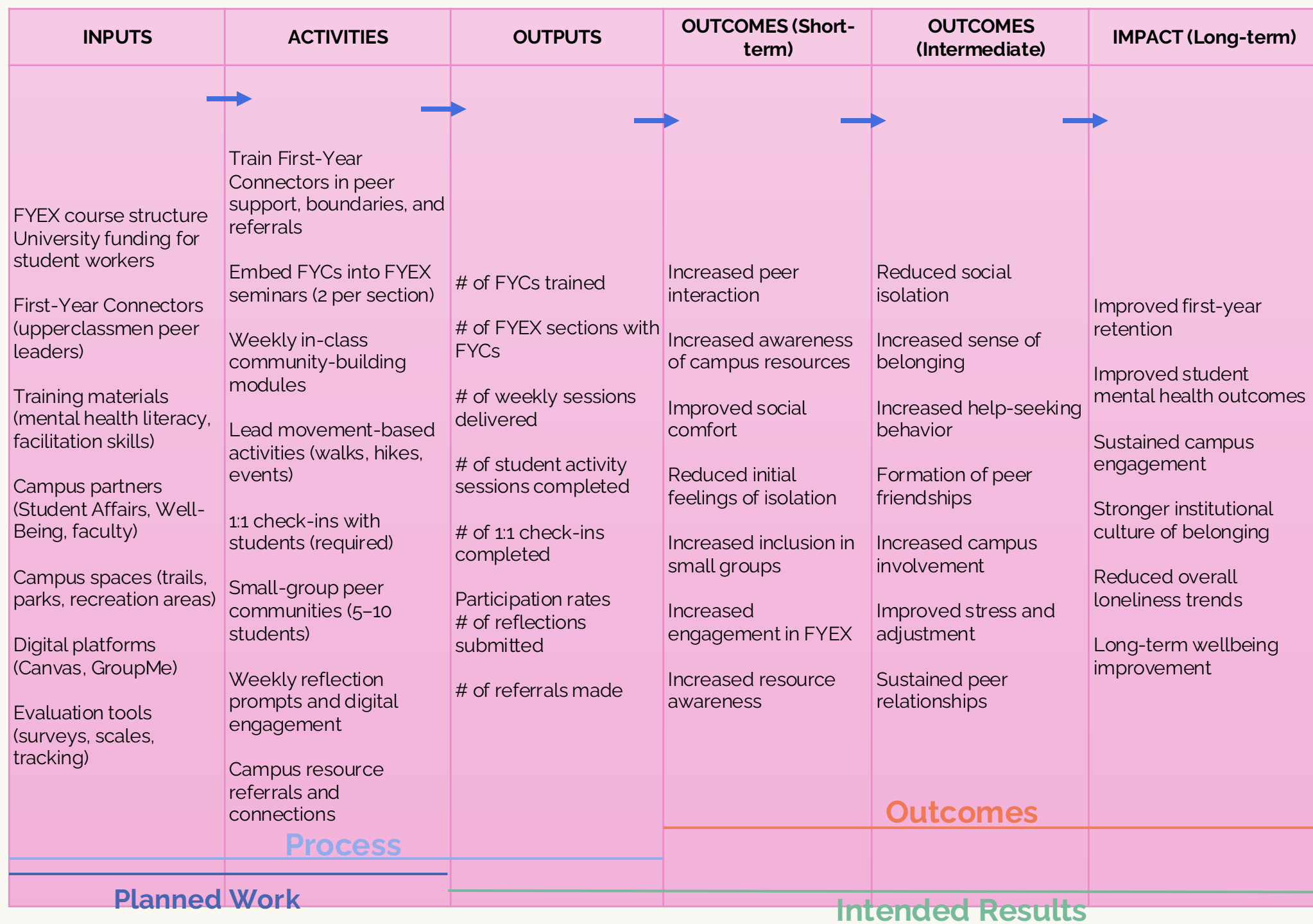
- **First-Year Connectors (FYCs):** Trained upperclassmen embedded in FYEX courses
- **Small Groups:** Consistent peer groups of 5–10 students per FYC
- **Weekly In-Class Sessions:** Structured community-building + engagement activities
- **Out-of-Class Activities:** 1 required FYC-led social/movement-based event per semester and 1 service-learning/community engagement-learning requirement
- **1:1 Check-In:** Individual holistic support meeting with FYC
- **Digital Support:** Canvas prompts + group messaging for reflection and connection providing intentional time to think about social connection during college transition

PROGRAM RATIONALE: FYEX CONNECTION PROGRAM

- Peer-led support reduces stigma and increases help-seeking behaviors in college students (Sontag-Padilla et al., 2018)
- Social connection is strongly linked to improved mental health and reduced loneliness among college students (Cipolletta et al., 2025; García-Pérez et al., 2025)
- Structured peer mentorship models improve belonging, engagement, and adjustment to university life (Cole & Reid, 2024)

PROGRAM LOGIC MODEL

(McKenzie, et. al 2023).



Problem Statement

- Social isolation is a significant public health concern among college students because it affects mental health, academic performance, and overall well-being.
- First-year undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas are especially affected due to the transition into a new academic and social environment.
- Many students experience loneliness as they adjust to campus life, build new relationships, and manage increased academic expectations.
- National data show that a large proportion of college students report feeling overwhelmed, emotionally exhausted, and disconnected during the academic year.
- Factors such as limited social networks, academic pressure, and reduced opportunities for engagement contribute to this issue.
- Without early support, social isolation can lead to increased stress, anxiety, depression, and unhealthy coping behaviors such as substance use.
- The FYEX Connection Program and First-Year Connectors aim to address this problem by creating structured opportunities for peer connection, support, and engagement during students' transition into college.

Literature Review Summary

- Social isolation is strongly associated with poor mental health outcomes in college students, including increased depression, anxiety, and stress (1, 2).
- First-year and transitioning students are especially vulnerable due to new environments, limited established social networks, and increased academic pressure (1).
- National and local data (NCHA; UMN CSHS) show high rates of loneliness, emotional exhaustion, and moderate-to-severe anxiety/depression among undergraduate students.
- Limited social support is linked to unhealthy coping behaviors, including substance use, and lower overall well-being (2).
- Strong peer relationships and a sense of belonging are associated with improved mental health, academic adjustment, and student retention (2, 3).
- Peer-led interventions reduce stigma, increase help-seeking behavior, and strengthen social connectedness among college students (3, 4).
- Structured group-based interventions demonstrate reductions in loneliness and improvements in mood, engagement, and stress levels (5).
- Digital and structured interventions can increase perceived social support and reduce loneliness over time (1).
- Group-based, person-centered approaches improve social connectedness and overall well-being across populations (6).
- Overall, the literature supports peer-led, structured engagement programs (such as FYEX-style initiatives) as effective strategies for reducing social isolation and improving undergraduate student mental health outcomes.

Data Brief

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- The figure was created using data from the Fall 2025 National College Health Assessment and the 2024 University of Minnesota College Student Health Survey.
- Minnesota college students report higher levels of frequent social isolation (34.2%) compared to the national average (28.0%) (7, 8).
- Minnesota college students report higher rates of moderate-to-severe depression (36.7%) compared to the national average (34.0%) (7, 8).
- Minnesota college students report slightly lower rates of moderate-to-severe anxiety (31.5%) compared to the national average (34.0%) (7, 8).
- Overall, the data indicates that Minnesota college students experience frequent social isolation at higher rates than students nationally.
- These findings suggest a significant disparity in social isolation and mental health outcomes within the broader Minnesota college student population.

Primary Data Collection

- A survey was chosen as the primary data collection tool because it allows us to effectively reach a wide range of undergraduate students, including those who may be experiencing higher levels of social isolation.
- Surveys provide a low-pressure, private, and self-paced way for students to respond, which is especially important when discussing sensitive topics like loneliness and mental health.
- The survey includes questions about students' demographics, campus experiences, and use of campus resources to understand how engagement relates to belonging.
- It also includes the UCLA Loneliness Scale, a validated tool used to measure feelings of loneliness and social isolation (9).
- Combining these questions helps us connect students' campus involvement, how students engaged with campus resources and organizations, with their perceived level of social isolation.
- The survey method allows for efficient, accessible, and meaningful data collection to better understand social isolation among University of St. Thomas students.

Program Proposal

- The FYEX Connection Program is a peer-led, course-embedded initiative designed to reduce social isolation and strengthen belonging among first-year students at the University of St. Thomas.
- The program integrates trained upperclassmen "First-Year Connectors" (FYCs) into First-Year Experience (FYEX) seminars to facilitate structured social connection, movement-based activities, and peer mentorship within required coursework.
- The program framework includes small group sessions led by FYCs, weekly in-class community-building sessions, one required out-of-class group activity, a community engagement/service-learning requirement, and a 1:1 holistic check-in with each student.
- A digital component (Canvas reflections and group messaging) supports ongoing engagement and reinforces connection outside of class.
- By embedding structured peer relationships directly into a required academic course, the program ensures equitable access to social support and encourages sustainable social connection-building habits.
- The program addresses first-year isolation at the point of highest need, promoting long-term student well-being and campus engagement.

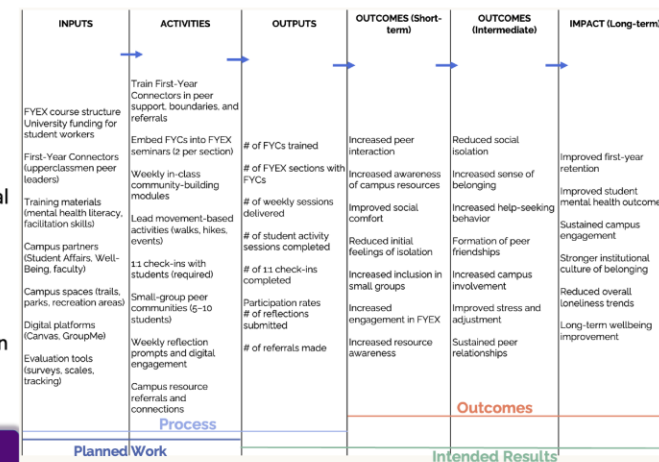


Figure 2. Logic Model for FYEX Connection & First-Year Connectors Program

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Thank you!

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